

is-plain-obj

Check if a value is a plain object

Sindre Sorhus, ehmicky, Rocktim Saikia, fisker Cheung,
Corey Farrell, Dimitri Benin, Michael Mayer

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30

COMMITTS

+541

LINES ADDED

18

ACTIVE DAYS

`is-plain-obj` is a tiny npm package that checks whether a value is a plain object. It counts an object as plain if it came from `{}`, `new Object()` or `Object.create(null)`. The package is at version 4.1.0, MIT licensed, and has no runtime dependencies.

1 *The problem and who it's for*

JavaScript developers often have to know whether a value is a plain object before they merge or clone it. Arrays, class instances and built-ins like `Math` should be treated differently. This package does only that check. I wrote it for library authors who want to stay at zero dependencies.

2 *How it works*

Usage is a single default import:

- These return true: `isPlainObject({foo: 'bar'})`, `isPlainObject(new Object())` and `isPlainObject(Object.create(null))`.
- These return false: `isPlainObject([1, 2, 3])`, `isPlainObject(new Unicorn())` for a class instance, and `isPlainObject(Math)`.
- It works across realms: an object created with `runInNewContext('{{}}')` from `node:vm` is still reported as plain.

The package ships as pure ESM (`"type": "module"`) with two published files, `index.js` and the TypeScript types in `index.d.ts`. It needs Node 18 or newer and is marked side-effect free. The test script runs `xo`, `ava` and `tsd`, so linting, unit tests and type tests all run together.

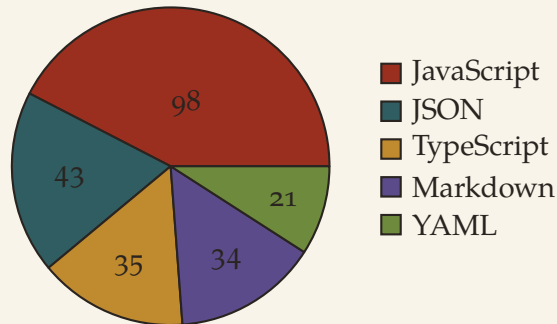


Figure 1 Lines of code by language. JavaScript holds the implementation and tests; the rest is package metadata, types, docs and CI config.

3 Development story

The first commit landed on 2015-07-11 and the most recent one on 2026-09-19, which puts 4089 calendar days between them. In that time the repository saw 30 commits from 7 authors, spread over just 18 active days, with 541 lines added and 245 removed. The commits came in short bursts with long gaps between them.

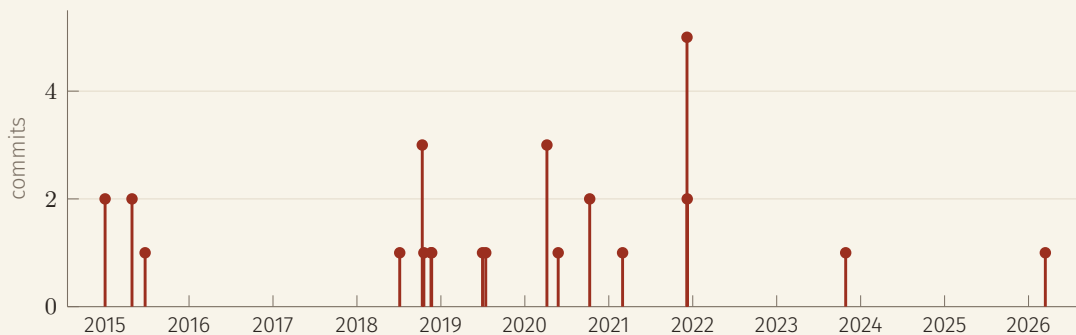


Figure 2 Commits per day.

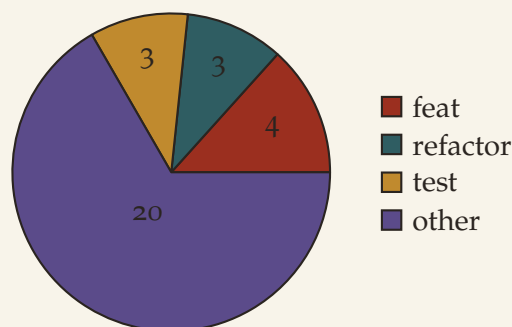


Figure 3 Commit types. Most commits fall under “other”.

The files that changed most were the package manifest, the tests and the readme, ahead of

the code itself. CI config shows up too, as both `.travis.yml` and `.github/workflows/main.yml`.

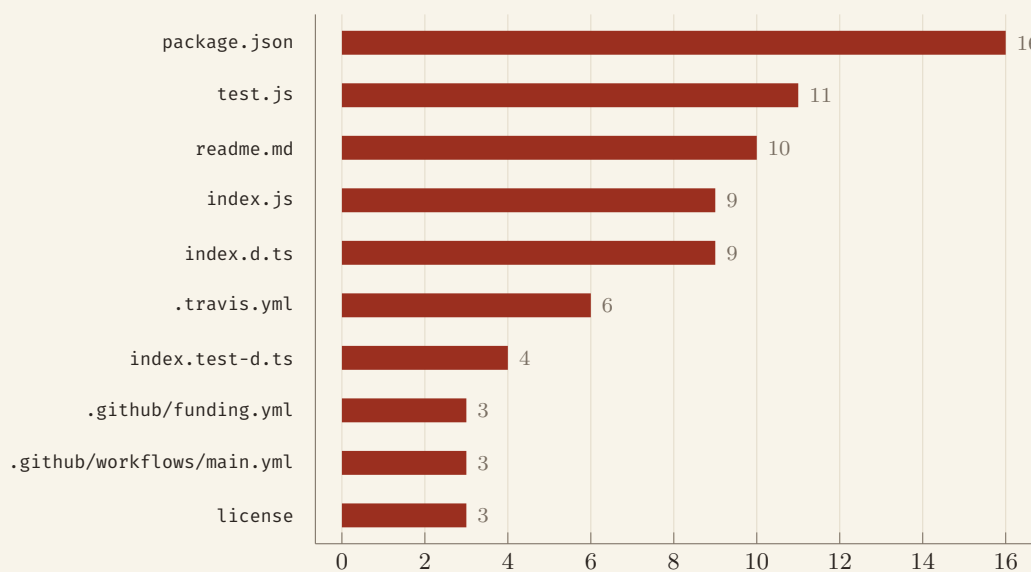


Figure 4 Most edited files.

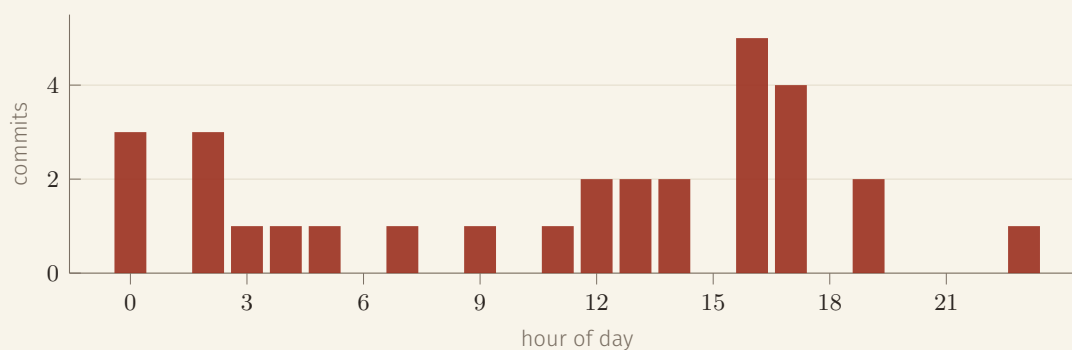


Figure 5 Commits by hour of day.

4 Challenges and what I learned

The hard part was cross-realm objects, meaning objects that come from iframes or `vm` contexts. `instanceof Object` fails for those because each realm has its own `Object`, so the check uses `Object.getPrototypeOf` instead. Moving the package to pure ESM also took some learning.

5 What's next

The plan is to keep it small. I may add more TypeScript type tests, and I'd like to benchmark it against `lodash.isPlainObject`.